



“[He] pulled ...
fabric off [her]
body, but she
**remained
covered, her
honor intact.**”

TRANS. HIMANSHU AGARWAL, THE MAHABHARATA

INDIAN DIGNITY

The central female character in the Indian epic, the *Mahabharata*—which is thought to have reached its final form by the 4th century CE—is the heroine Draupadi. After Draupadi’s husband inadvertently loses her to his wicked cousins in a game of dice, she is publicly dragged away by one of her enemies, who begins to tug at her sari in an attempt to disrobe her. As a pious and brave woman, Draupadi prays to Lord Krishna for protection, and he rescues her from humiliation by making her sari infinitely long so that she cannot be undressed. The *Mahabharata* reflects Indian society’s patriarchal attitudes but Draupadi’s actions in this scene—in which she boldly defends her honor—defy the Indian ideal of female submissiveness.